Rabbani, Sayyaf, all of them were trained by the ISI in Peshawar [in 1970s and 1980s]. And during the [anti-Soviet] jihad all of them, including Hekmatyar, had good relations with the ISI. But when they came to Afghanistan, and changed their direction. The only one [Hekmatyar] who did not have any support [from countries other than Pakistan], did not change. He is also looking to change direction and establish relations with other countries', says Tasal.[106] The conciliators within India's policymaking circuit understood and appreciated this logic of engagement, and viewed it as a risky but necessary step to develop influence on hitherto estranged Pashtun insurgents.

Similar to Hizb-e-Islami, the Afghan Taliban also viewed India as a powerful regional actor to be engaged with in their quest to gain strategic autonomy from Pakistan, and began signaling the same. The timing of such outreach to India by the Taliban was interesting, for this is when India's former UF allies were getting slightly disillusioned by India's reluctance to support them in their domestic political battles (and were being lobbied by Pakistan). Islamabad's pressure on the Afghan Taliban and politicking between different insurgent networks had angered the Pashtun communities tremendously. The ISI had pitched the Peshawar shura against the Quetta shura, and the Haqqani network against almost every other faction. It held Mullah Omar and other Taliban figures in Pakistan and supplied fighters to the Pashtun areas of Afghanistan. Such actions had problematised Pakistan's image among the border tribes. Military actions in South Waziristan further undermined its image among Pashtuns. As Akbar Agha put it, 'Pakistan is the country that shows its back to us [Afghanistan] ... and in that situation we have India to have close and friendly relations with, because India is a country that wants, forever, to make good brotherly relations with us'.[107] Various Afghan Taliban factions sent feelers to India at different points in time. India silently entertained some of them.[108] But more often than not, after this initial interaction, the Afghan Taliban would retreat out of fear of reprisals from Pakistan. For Menon, the architect of India's conciliatory approach, the Afghan Taliban's toing-and-froing raised a pertinent question which were how far can the Taliban take its relations with India? '*Unki bhi majbooriyan hoti hain* [they also have their compulsions] ... I don't think that we [India] should put too much